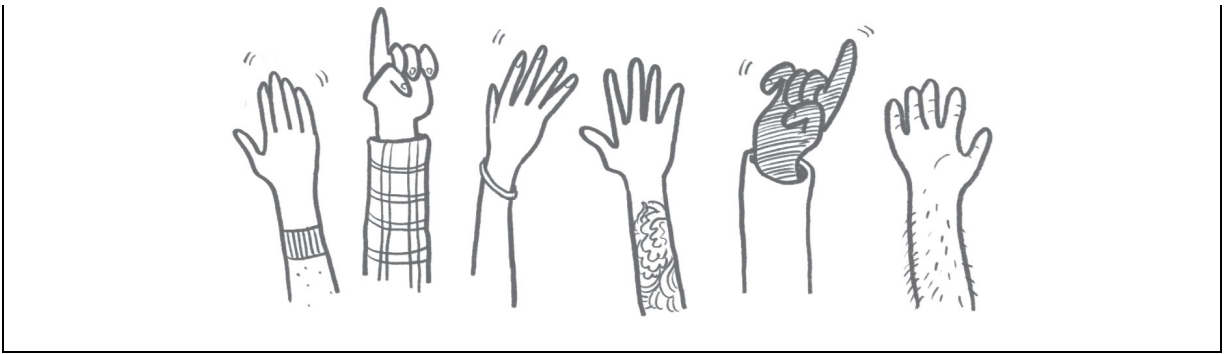




The Family Treasure Hunt

My boys can come to blows over sharing a new toy . . . and then 15 minutes later it's discarded on the floor with all the other figurines, cars and Bob the Builder merch.

My wife now only puts out four toys for the boys to play with; the rest are packed away.

She does this based on a study from the University of Toledo published in *Infant Behavior and Development*, where researchers set up kids younger than three in rooms with either four or 16 toys.

The researchers observed their play habits and found the kids with four toys engaged 'in longer periods of play with a single toy, allowing better focus to explore and play more creatively'.

The same thing happens when we do this with our boys.

Amazingly, they fight less, use their imaginations more, and get a buzz when the toys are rotated and 'new' ones emerge from the cupboard.

It's said that a typical British kid owns 238 toys yet only plays with 12, meaning that 95 per cent of them are unused.

I'm sure there's a lot of stuff your kids once pestered you about that now lies around gathering dust, right?

Well, this is a perfect opportunity to tick off the second of the Barefoot Ten . . . **'before your kids leave home, they should have bought and sold something second-hand'**.